

Volkspistole

The **Volkspistole** ('People's Pistol') was a prototype pistol produced by Carl Walther GmbH, Mauser-Werke and Gustloff-Werke in 1945 for an emergency German pistol design to help mitigate the loss of pistols before the war's end in Europe.

History

In the first half of 1944, the German troops had lost more than 110,000 pistols, when the project started (by the end of the year, an additional 170,000 had been lost), as Carl Walther GmbH, Mauser, and Spreewerk, the three major producers of the current service pistol, the Walther P38, could not produce P38s fast enough to account for their losses. It was to be assembled from simple steel pressings with a minimum of machined parts and to be used by the Volkssturm.^[1] Only prototypes were produced before the end of World War II. These prototypes had various unusual locking systems to figure out a cheaper design than the short recoil action of the P38. They also all reused the P38's magazine, another pivotal point in the plan's goal for low-cost production. Three prototypes were designed by Walther,^[2] Mauser^[3] and Gustloff-Werke, and all three failed. These prototypes had slightly different actions:

- For the Walther design, a rotating barrel design, extremely unique for the time, and only seen on a handful of modern handguns, such as the Beretta Px4 Storm. The original design failed, and Walther soon switched to a milled slide, contrary to the specifications of the program.^[4]
- For the Gustloff-Werke design, they simply submitted a 9×19mm redesign of a previous (also failed) simple blowback prototype of Gustloff-Werke's for the 7.65×21mm Parabellum cartridge designed for the original Luger pistol. While it is rumored that

Volkspistole (People's Pistol)



Type	Semi-Automatic Pistol
Place of origin	Nazi Germany
Service history	
In service	1945
Used by	-
Production history	
Designer	Various
Designed	1944 -1945
Manufacturer	<u>Carl Walther GmbH</u> <u>Mauser-Werke</u> <u>Gustloff-Werke</u>
Produced	1945
No. built	~12 or 24 (estimated)
Specifications	
Mass	1.088 kg (2.40 lb)
Length	215 mm (8.5 in)
Barrel length	128 mm (5.0 in)
Height	140 mm (5.5 in)
Cartridge	<u>9×19mm Parabellum</u>
Barrels	Rifled (Mauser) Smoothbore (Gustloff) Rotating barrel (Walther)

five Gustloff-Werke examples were made, there is no primary source, and no currently remaining designs exist. Gustloff-Werke never designed a successful firearm (their only other major designs being the Volkssturmgewehr and the first pistol), and their only contribution to firearms mainly focused on concentration camp slave labor producing Karabiner 98k.^{[5][6]}

- Mauser had been working in 1943 and early 1944 on a simpler weapon to replace the P38 under the project name M.7057. Valuable lessons had already been learned from simplifying the Mauser HSc pistol which received a simplified trigger and a sheet metal slide. When the official request came from the military authorities for a simple pistol chambered in 9 mm, Mauser developed a blowback weapon with the simplest fashioning of the individual parts. The Mauser pistol took about 30% fewer working hours and about 20% less raw material to produce than the P38. Testing took place at the end of 1944 which revealed issues with the double-action trigger pull. Mauser started working on new models but it is unclear if any were completed by the end of the war.

Action	<u>Blowback</u>
Rate of fire	116 rpm (Walther) (estimated) 119 rpm (Mauser) (estimated) 109 rpm (Gustloff) (estimated)
Muzzle velocity	381 m/s (1,250 ft/s)
Effective firing range	50 m (160 ft)
Maximum firing range	75 m (246 ft)
Feed system	8 round detachable box magazine
Sights	Iron sights

References

1. McCollum, Ian (2013-03-06). "The Walther Volkspistole" (<https://www.forgottenweapons.com/the-walther-volkspistole/>). *Forgotten Weapons*. Retrieved 2022-06-28.
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 3. McCollum, Ian (June 22, 2010). "Mauser Volkspistole Video" (<http://www.forgottenweapons.com/mauser-volkspistole/>). *Forgottenweapons.com*. Retrieved August 22, 2012.
 4. McCollum, Ian (March 11, 2015), *Walther Volkspistole* (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZbsekVhgets>), *Forgotten Weapons*, retrieved 2022-06-28
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 6. Katz, Stephen T (2019). *The Holocaust and New World Slavery*. Cambridge University Press (published May 2019). pp. 837–852. ISBN 9781108227483. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781108227483.018> Publisher: Cambridge University Press Print publication year: 2019
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External links

- [Walther *Volkspistole* \(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZbsekVhgets\)](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZbsekVhgets) Forgotten Weapons
- [Mauser *Volkspistole* \(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G9WZ5JeDFZ4\)](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G9WZ5JeDFZ4) Forgotten Weapons
- [German Late-War Pistols of World War II \(https://sadefensejournal.com/german-late-war-pistols-of-world-war-ii/\)](https://sadefensejournal.com/german-late-war-pistols-of-world-war-ii/)

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